

HEAT IS ON
A protest by the Pandits in Jammu, May 13

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the Amarnath Yatra in the face of a heightened threat. The Resistance Front, an alleged offshoot of the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT), had issued a statement speaking of "dirty politics" behind the upscaling of the Yatra. "From 15,000 to 800,000 pilgrim registrations and from 15 days to 80 days, this is meant to provoke the sensitivities of Kashmir," it said.

The threat appears real: a bus carrying pilgrims from the Vaishno Devi shrine in Katra was targeted with a sticky bomb on May 13,

THE PANDITS WANT TO MOVE OUT BUT THE CENTRE DOES NOT WANT ANOTHER HINDU EXODUS

leaving four dead and nearly two dozen injured. The little-known Jammu and Kashmir Freedom Fighters owned up to the attack. Extra layers of security—over 400 companies of central forces, besides drones—are being built in along the route to ensure the yatra, beginning June 30, goes smoothly. The pilgrims will also be equipped with radio frequency identification (RFID) tags for tracking.

Another reason for disquiet: for all the success in pruning the militant roster, their ranks seem to be swelling again. Security officials admit the situation is "not stable". In the past six months, over 50 youth have reportedly joined the militants and reports of smuggling of arms and sticky bombs have become almost routine. A drone laden with eight sticky bombs and grenades that was intercepted in Kathua on May 29 is being seen as only the tip of the iceberg. Official data records the seizure of 100-odd handguns this year. In one of the biggest seizures, 15 handguns, 30 magazines, 300 rounds and a silencer were retrieved from Srinagar's Chanapora on May 23. Two youths were arrested. Police describes them as "hybrid militants", who live normal lives with their families till activated online by their handlers. "It needs little training to pull the trigger of a pistol," says a police official, explaining the deluge of consignments from across the border. "They receive instructions online about the training and target."

The targeted attacks fit into this plot: an intelligence officer speaks of a "policy decision" by Pakistani agencies. The attacks are mostly being executed by "boys in their teens or early 20s...they are just pulling the trigger," he says. Local maulvis were seen preaching peace this time, but that can't ease the panic among Pandits. With a high-stakes yatra coming up too, nor can New Delhi relax. ■

VPN

HIDE, BUT SEEK

By Kaushik Deka

On April 28, India's cybersecurity watchdog Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) issued a set of rules—called Cyber Security Directions—which require companies offering Virtual Private Networks (VPNs) to store in their servers a wide range of data on their subscribers, including names, addresses, contact numbers, email addresses, IP addresses, ownership patterns and purpose of hiring the services, for a period of five years. The directive made it mandatory for VPN service providers to report cyber security breach incidents within six hours of noticing them. Failure to comply can invite a jail term of one year or a fine of up to Rs 1 lakh, or both. Corporate and enterprise VPNs have been exempted from the regulations, expected to come into effect on June 27.

In response, ExpressVPN, a popular VPN service provider owned by British Virgin Islands-based Express Technologies, announced its exit from India. Calling it an assault on the right to privacy, activists and legal experts have labelled it as a government ploy to step up surveillance. The government claims the move would protect vulnerable citizens from cybercrimes.

Establishing an encrypted connection between computers and the internet and providing a private route for data, a VPN service protects users by preventing their IP addresses from being tracked by websites, law enforcement agencies, cybercriminals and others. Most users subscribe to VPN services to access company networks securely, remain anonymous, access geo-restricted content, get